dignity and grace and ‘in spite of the ties of love between her and H. M. [Akbar]’, Abu’l Fazl tells us, ‘she had taken up her residence in the neighbourhood of the tomb of [Humayun] and devoted herself to works of charity’. A Jesuit traveller, Father Monserrate agreed that ‘one of his wives had loved [Humayun] so faithfully that she had had a small house built by the tomb and watched there till the day of her death. Throughout her widowhood she devoted herself to prayer and to alms-giving.’ Monserrate sighed that ‘had she only been a Christian, hers would have been the life of a heroine’. After her return from Mecca, therefore, Haji Begum remained at the site of the construction of Humayun’s tomb, where men hauled the red sandstone from quarries in Rajasthan and Hindustani craftsmen transformed a Persian vision from wood into stone. Abu’l Fazl, who naturally was not present at the time, only mentioned succinctly that the tomb was built by Akbar but then Abu’l Fazl, as we will see later, was never shy to claim all grand achievements on Akbar’s behalf. Some scholars have argued that the scale of the building would necessarily imply an imperial patron but Mughal women, especially senior wives, were independently wealthy. Hamida Banu would leave a fortune upon her death and Haji Begum would live on in the Arab Sarai after the hajj, maintaining 500 women a day on her alms. Some of the money for the project may have come from Akbar, certainly, but its memory-keeper was Haji Begum, once Empress of Hindustan.

Bairam Khan, meanwhile, never did reach Mecca. He was murdered on the shores of the Sahasralinga Lake in Gujarat in an act of revenge by an Afghan youth whose father had been killed at the Battle of Machhiwara, commanded by Bairam Khan. When Akbar heard of this random act of violence, he immediately summoned Bairam Khan’s widow, Salima Sultan Begum, his cousin and a Timurid princess, along with her stepson, Abdur Rahim, to his court. Akbar married Salima Sultan Begum and yet another powerful, influential Timurid woman joined the Mughal harem.

While the Timurid women were busy securing their immortal legacies Akbar, too, was about to show signs of the blistering force of nature he was to become. For five years, he had immersed himself in the feral countryside of Hindustan, and the pursuit of its cheetahs, tigers, antelope, and elephants, content to leave the affairs of his empire to capable allies. He had watched his clan-based, imperious, and prickly nobility grow dangerously assertive and territorial. Finally, it was an act of wilful arrogance and presumption